midwifed the PRC's entrance into the World Trade Organization, and successive US leaders ignored growing evidence of China's industrial and cyber espionage of both US government and private American business secrets. The 1999 Cox Commission Report detailed how Chinese agents stole some of America's most sensitive nuclear and ballistic missile technology, and a later report by Mandiant Corporation, in February 2013, revealed years of cyber espionage against a variety of US targets.[2]

However, it was during the Barack Obama administration that the real seeds of the 2025 Littoral War were laid. Building off the Bush administration's elevation of high-level bilateral talks into the "Strategic and Economic Dialogue," the Obama administration energetically engaged the Chinese government. Ostensibly pushing back against Beijing's rampant cyber espionage, Obama and new Chinese leader Xi Jinping agreed at the 2013 Sunnylands Summit that China would rein in its official and quasi-official hackers.[3] Like his predecessors, Obama traveled to China, though his 2016 visit revealed strains in bilateral ties when he was subjected to protocol insults on his arrival at the airport and hotel.[4]

Petty jockeying aside, however, serious challenges to Asian regional stability emerged during Obama's two terms. Most egregious was Beijing's decision to build and fortify islands in disputed maritime territory in the South China Sea. Ownership of various coral reefs and shoals in the Spratly and Paracel island chains had long been contested between China and a host of Southeast Asian countries. Many had built modest defensive installations on some of their possessions, yet Beijing claimed that then secretary of state Hillary Clinton's comments at a regional security meeting in 2010 demonstrated US antagonism toward China's rightful claims.[5] Clinton had stated that the Obama administration considered the peaceful multilateral resolution of competing territorial claims to be in the United States' national interest. Clinton's statements were combined with articulation of a "rebalance" or "pivot" to Asia, an assertion by Obama officials that the Asia-Pacific was the key geopolitical focus for America. To buttress the pivot, in addition to